Zaxonite Systems Ltd
Fraud Intelligence Report 2026



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Executive Summary

This report presents an analysis of UK fraud using data from the Office for National Statistics (ONS), Crime Survey for England and Wales (CSEW), Cifas and UK Finance. It examines the scale of fraud, changes across major fraud categories and longer-term trends within payment fraud.

The latest data indicates that fraud remains a significant source of harm in the UK. An estimated 4.48 million fraud incidents were recorded within the analysed ONS/CSEW data, affecting approximately 3.80 million victims and representing an estimated 7.8% of the adult population.

Analysis of Cifas data shows that fraud categories are not moving uniformly. Overall recorded cases increased by approximately 5.2% year on year, but substantially different movements are visible beneath the headline figure. Application fraud excluding mortgages increased by 28.6%, while banking and credit industry fraud increased by approximately 7.4%. Other categories, including mortgage-related fraud and telecom industry fraud, recorded declines.

The increase in application fraud requires careful interpretation. Cifas states that the reported increase was partly influenced by a filing error from one member. The figure should therefore be treated as an indicator requiring context rather than evidence of an equivalent increase in underlying fraudulent activity.

Longer-term payment fraud data also demonstrates how the composition of fraud has changed over time. Plastic card fraud and remote purchase fraud account for substantial volumes within the latest reporting period, while individual fraud types follow different historical trajectories. This reinforces the importance of examining specific fraud mechanisms rather than relying solely on aggregate fraud totals.

Taken together, the analysis demonstrates a fragmented and evolving fraud environment. Headline totals provide useful context, but meaningful risk intelligence requires examination of individual categories, historical movement and the limitations of the underlying evidence.

The accompanying Zaxonite Fraud Intelligence dashboard has been developed to support this analysis through interactive category, reporting-period and fraud-type exploration. The dashboard and this report are intended as analytical decision-support tools. They provide structured evidence and context, rather than determining whether individual activity is fraudulent.

UK Fraud Landscape

Power BI – Analysis Page 1

Fraud remains a major source of crime and financial harm in the UK. The latest ONS and Crime Survey for England and Wales data used in this analysis estimates 4.48 million fraud incidents, involving approximately 3.80 million victims.

This represents an estimated 7.8% of the adult population. The figures show that fraud is not a small or isolated problem. It affects a significant number of people and continues to create risk for individuals, businesses and financial organisations.

Fraud is not one single problem

The overall fraud figure covers several different types of activity. These categories can move in different directions and at very different rates.
Banking and credit industry fraud remains the largest category within the Cifas data analysed, increasing from approximately 289,000 cases to 310,000 cases, a rise of 7.4%.

Application fraud excluding mortgages recorded the strongest percentage increase. Cases rose from 61,012 to 78,455, an increase of 28.6%.
Other categories moved in the opposite direction. Mortgage-related fraud fell by approximately 10.5%, while telecom industry fraud fell by approximately 10.4%.

Why category-level analysis matters

Overall Cifas cases increased by approximately 5.2%, but this headline figure hides much larger differences between individual fraud categories.

For organisations assessing fraud risk, the direction of individual categories can therefore be more useful than the overall figure alone. A relatively modest change in total fraud can exist alongside rapid growth in a specific type of fraud.

This is why the Zaxonite analysis separates overall fraud levels from category-level change. It allows emerging areas of concern to be identified without treating every type of fraud as though it is following the same pattern.

Data note

Changes in recorded fraud can be affected by reporting practices, member submissions and data quality as well as changes in actual fraud activity. Cifas states that the increase in application fraud was partly affected by a filing error from one member. This should be considered when interpreting the 28.6% increase.

Fraud Category Intelligence

Power BI – Analysis page 2

The second dashboard page examines how individual fraud categories changed between the year ending March 2025 and the year ending March 2026. This provides more detail than the overall fraud figure and helps identify which categories are showing the strongest growth or decline.

Across the Cifas categories included in the analysis, recorded cases increased from approximately 688,000 to 724,000, an overall increase of 5.2%. This represents approximately 35,875 additional recorded cases.

Application fraud shows the strongest growth

Application fraud excluding mortgages recorded the largest percentage increase in the dataset. Cases increased from 61,012 in 2025 to 78,455 in 2026, an increase of 17,443 cases, or 28.6%.

This places application fraud first for year-on-year growth among the categories analysed. The increase is considerably higher than the overall Cifas growth rate of 5.2%. The result should be interpreted with the stated Cifas data caveat. Cifas reports that the increase in application fraud was partly affected by a filing error from one member. The figure remains useful for analysis but should not be interpreted as a direct measure of growth in underlying fraudulent activity.

Banking and credit fraud remains high volume

Banking and credit industry fraud increased from approximately 289,000 to 310,000 cases, representing growth of 7.4% and more than 21,000 additional cases.

While its percentage growth is lower than application fraud, the much larger number of cases means even a smaller percentage increase represents a significant change in recorded fraud volume.

This distinction between growth rate and case volume is important. A rapidly growing category may indicate an emerging area of concern, while a slower-growing category can still represent a much larger operational risk because of its overall scale.

Several categories declined

Not every category increased during the period. Mortgage-related fraud fell by approximately 10.5%, while telecom industry fraud fell by approximately 10.4%. Business trading fraud recorded an even larger percentage decline, although from a much smaller number of cases.

These differences show why the overall 5.2% increase should not be applied equally across the fraud landscape. Individual categories are following different patterns.

Analytical finding

The category analysis shows a mixed fraud environment. Application fraud stands out for its rate of growth, while banking and credit industry fraud remains significant because of its much larger volume.

For fraud monitoring and risk assessment, both measures matter. **Percentage change can help identify emerging movement, while case volume shows the scale of the activity being recorded.**

The interactive dashboard allows users to select individual fraud categories and compare their 2025 and 2026 case volumes, year-on-year change, absolute case change and growth ranking against the overall fraud trend.

Payment Fraud Intelligence

Power BI - Analysis Page 3

The third dashboard page examines how different types of payment fraud have changed over time. Unlike the previous section, which compares fraud categories between two reporting years, this analysis focuses on long-term trends across multiple reporting periods.

The data shows that payment fraud does not follow a single pattern. Individual fraud types have grown, declined and changed direction at different points in time.

Plastic card fraud remains the largest category

Within the latest reporting period, Plastic Card Fraud represents the largest number of recorded cases in the payment fraud dataset.

Remote Purchase Fraud also accounts for a substantial volume of cases. This reflects the continuing importance of fraud involving transactions where the cardholder and payment card are not physically present at the point of purchase.

Other types, including Lost and Stolen, Card ID Theft, Remote Banking Fraud and Cheque Fraud, account for smaller volumes but show their own patterns over time.

The difference in scale between these categories is important. A fraud type does not need to show the fastest growth to remain a significant source of fraud activity.

Long-term trends show significant change

The historical data shows clear changes in payment fraud since 2010/11.

Remote Purchase Fraud increased strongly during the earlier part of the period before reaching much higher levels in later years. Remote Banking Fraud followed a different pattern, with lower overall case volumes and more gradual changes.

Plastic Card Fraud remains particularly significant because of its overall scale. Other categories have experienced periods of growth followed by decline or stabilisation.

These trends show why a single reporting year provides only part of the picture. Historical analysis helps identify whether a change is unusual or part of a longer pattern.

Reporting periods provide useful context

The dashboard allows individual reporting periods to be selected and compared with the previously available period.

This makes it possible to examine the number of cases recorded during a specific period, the percentage change from the previous period and the historical peak for the selected fraud type.

The analysis also shows that not every fraud type has data available across the full historical period. Where a value is unavailable, the dashboard does not treat the missing observation as zero. This avoids creating a false impression that no fraud occurred during that period.

Different fraud types require different interpretation

The payment fraud data highlights an important point for fraud analysis. Changes in overall payment fraud can be driven by very different movements within individual fraud types.

A rise in one area can occur alongside a decline in another. High-volume fraud types can also have a much greater effect on the overall figures than smaller categories experiencing larger percentage changes.

For this reason, both case volume and historical direction should be considered when assessing payment fraud trends.

Analytical finding

The long-term data shows that payment fraud is continually changing rather than moving in one consistent direction.

The strongest insight comes from examining individual fraud types across time. This provides context that cannot be obtained from headline totals alone and helps distinguish short-term movement from longer-term change.

The interactive dashboard supports this analysis by allowing users to select reporting periods and individual fraud types, compare period-on-period movement and examine historical case trends.

Data Sources & Methodology

This report combines publicly available UK fraud data from several established sources. Each dataset covers a different part of the fraud landscape and has been analysed separately before being presented within the Zaxonite Fraud Intelligence dashboard.

Data Sources

Office for National Statistics and Crime Survey for England and Wales

ONS and Crime Survey for England and Wales data provides the high-level estimates used to describe the scale of fraud affecting adults in England and Wales.

This includes estimated fraud incidents, estimated victims and the proportion of adults affected by fraud.

Cifas

Cifas data is used to analyse changes across recorded fraud categories between the year ending March 2025 and the year ending March 2026.

The analysis includes banking and credit industry fraud, application fraud, mortgage-related fraud, telecom industry fraud and other recorded categories.

UK Finance

UK Finance data provides the historical payment fraud series used within the Payment Fraud Intelligence analysis.

This dataset covers several payment fraud types across multiple reporting periods, allowing changes in case volumes and longer-term trends to be examined.

Data Preparation

Source data was reviewed and prepared before analysis. This included checking reporting-period labels, data types, category names, missing values and the consistency of records used within the dashboard.

Reporting periods within the payment fraud dataset were standardised and assigned a chronological sort order to ensure that historical trends were displayed correctly.

Missing observations were retained as unavailable values rather than automatically being treated as zero. This is important because the absence of a reported value does not necessarily mean that no fraud occurred.

Calculations

Year-on-year percentage change was calculated by comparing the latest reporting value with the corresponding value from the previous period.

Absolute case change was also calculated to distinguish percentage growth from the actual change in recorded case volume.

Historical payment fraud measures were used to compare selected reporting periods, previous periods and peak recorded case volumes.

These calculations support comparison and trend analysis. They do not alter the underlying source figures.

Analytical Approach

The analysis considers both scale and direction of change.

Case volumes are used to understand the size of individual fraud categories, while percentage changes help identify categories showing notable growth or decline. Historical data is used to provide further context and distinguish recent movement from longer-term patterns.

The datasets have not been combined into a single measure of UK fraud. ONS/CSEW, Cifas and UK Finance use different collection methods, definitions and reporting structures. Results from each source are therefore presented within their appropriate analytical context.

Data Responsibility

Zaxonite Systems Ltd has analysed, prepared and visualised the source data for this report. Zaxonite is not the producer of the underlying official or industry statistics.
The analysis is intended to support understanding of fraud patterns and trends. Source figures remain subject to the definitions, methodology, revisions and limitations of the organisations that originally produced them.

Limitations & Interpretation

This analysis should be interpreted within the limitations of the underlying data.

The datasets used in this report measure different aspects of fraud and use different definitions, reporting methods and collection processes. Figures from ONS/CSEW, Cifas and UK Finance should therefore not be directly combined.

Recorded fraud does not represent every instance of fraud. Changes in reporting practices, data quality and member submissions can affect reported figures. Cifas has stated that the increase in application fraud was partly influenced by a filing error from one member.

Missing historical observations have not been treated as zero. Where data is unavailable, no assumption has been made about the level of fraud during that period.

Percentage changes should also be considered alongside case volumes. Large percentage movements can result from relatively small starting values.

The analysis identifies patterns and changes within the available data. It does not establish the cause of those changes or predict future fraud levels.

The findings should therefore be used as supporting evidence for further analysis and informed decision-making, rather than as a standalone assessment of fraud risk.

Sources & References

The analysis in this report is based on publicly available fraud statistics and industry data published by the following organisations.

Office for National Statistics (ONS)

Crime Survey for England and Wales and associated fraud statistics. Used for estimates of fraud incidents, victims and the proportion of adults affected by fraud.

Cifas

Fraudscape and associated fraud data. Used for analysis of recorded fraud categories and year-on-year changes, including banking and credit industry fraud and application fraud.

UK Finance

Annual Fraud Report and associated payment fraud statistics. Used for the historical analysis of payment fraud types and case volumes.

Important Note

The underlying statistics remain the property of their respective publishers. Zaxonite Systems Ltd has prepared, analysed and visualised the data for the purposes of this report.

Figures should be read alongside the original publishers' methodology, definitions and data-quality notes.

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